The difficulty of being a Tendulkar

There is a common misconception that cricketers' families have an easy time of it. On the contrary, in my absence Anjali had to do most of the parenting, and bringing up two young kids almost on her own was anything but easy. For the children too it was hard at times. They were not always able to do the things normal kids enjoy and, with their father away for long periods, they missed out on fatherly affection and care.

When Arjun was just nine months old, for example, I was going to Germany to visit the Adidas factory and asked Anjali if she would like to come along. I was going for only five days and Anjali hadn't left home for nine months – after Arjun's birth. We left Sara and Arjun with her parents in India. It was on the third night away that calamity struck. We had finished work in the Adidas factory and had retreated to a small village for the evening when Anjali got a call from Dr Ajit Gajendragadkar, who asked us to come back as soon as possible. We were informed that Anjali's mother had suffered a brain haemorrhage (from which she later recovered) and was in the hospital unconscious, while Arjun was seriously sick at home.

It was night-time in Germany and the earliest we could leave for India was the following morning. All through the journey the next day we kept worrying about who was taking care of nine-month-old Arjun. When we finally got home, the first sight of Arjun reduced us both to tears. He had lost weight and had a pained expression in his eyes. While there was a glint of happiness in seeing us both back at home, his expression was predominantly one of hurt, as if to ask why we had to leave him and go away. Since then, Anjali has never left the kids alone at home to travel abroad with me.

Another example occurred soon after we had been knocked out of the World Cup in the Caribbean in March 2007. We had played poorly in the tournament and it was a low for the country. My family were aware that the repercussions of the first-round exit might reach the kids. As a precautionary measure, Anjali tried to explain to Arjun, who was seven years old at the time, that if someone made a snide comment about his dad at school, he should ignore it; he should just say that it was disappointing and we would surely do better the next time. When a friend of his accosted him at school and said that India had lost because his dad had got out for zero, our advice went out of his head and Arjun